WEST

EDITION 2026–27



INFO BOOKLET

For *High Schools*

How your strongest students work on real companies for college credit, at no cost to the school.

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for heads of school, principals, counselors and teachers.

We ask partner schools for one thing: to name their most capable students. Those students, called Builder Scholars, join teams with college students and do real work for experienced founders and operators. They earn college credit for it, with no homework and no tests beyond the work itself. The school pays nothing.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR HIGH SCHOOLS

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This booklet is written for high schools. Four companion booklets cover the program for parents, students, founders and executives and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

What West Ventures is

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

23

Companies served by student teams so far

78

Students who have worked on a team

500

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

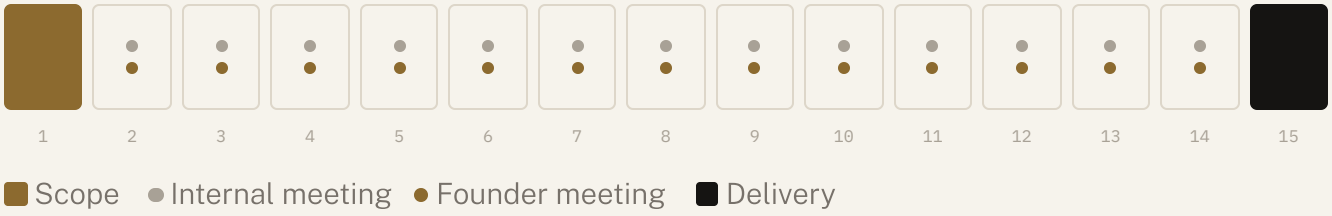
03 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

How a project works

One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM



Before	The studio matches the project with a team and a project lead, and introduces them to the founder.
Week one	The founder and the project lead write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver.
Every week	Two meetings. One internal, with the project lead, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope.
End of term	The team delivers and hands over. The project lead evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project.
After	Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture.

04 · THE TEAM

The team

About five students, an experienced project lead and the founder.



Two college students, one of whom leads the team.

Three high school Builder Scholars, nominated by their schools.

Teams mix students from different schools on purpose. Each team is coached by a volunteer project lead: an experienced professional who runs the internal meeting, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Studio staff oversee every team.

TIME EACH WEEK

Team leader	College student	5 to 10 hours
Contributor	College student	4 to 8 hours
Builder Scholar	High school student	About 3 hours
Project lead	Volunteer professional	Two meetings, plus review
Founder	The company	About 1 hour

05 · EXPECTATIONS

What each party commits to

The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.

The school

- Name one contact who nominates students.
- Nominate two to five capable students each term.
- Let students take part alongside their coursework.

The project lead

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project leads.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project lead in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

06 · CREDIT

College credit, *no homework*

Builder Scholars earn college credit through Austin Christian University for the work they do on their team. There are no tests and no assignments created for the course. Students submit evidence of the work they already produce for their founder, and their project lead evaluates it.

The studio never creates work the founder did not ask for.

Partner schools nominate two to five students a term. The studio interviews each nominee and contacts the family. Schools pay nothing; there is no quota and no minimum.

For the fall 2026 cohort, 35 high school seniors were selected from hundreds of nominees nationwide.



VALLEY CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



THE STONY BROOK SCHOOL



OAKS CHRISTIAN SCHOOL

Partner schools include Sierra Canyon School, Santa Fe Christian Schools, Gilbert Christian Schools, Greater Atlanta Christian School, Little Rock Christian Academy, Jupiter Christian School and others.

07 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

Outcomes for students

Responsibility is earned one term at a time.

01	**Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit.
02	**Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope.
03	**Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder.
04	**Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time.

78

Students who have worked on a team

21

Student Fellows named

2×

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project lead who saw the work.

08 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

Name
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

Name
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

Name
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

Name
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

09 · FROM FOUNDERS

From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

10 · THE NETWORK

The network



VALLEY CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



THE STONY BROOK SCHOOL



OAKS CHRISTIAN SCHOOL



SIERRA CANYON SCHOOL



SANTA FE CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS



GILBERT CHRISTIAN SCHOOLS

PARTNER HIGH SCHOOLS

Valley Christian School
The Stony Brook School
Oaks Christian School
Sierra Canyon School
Santa Fe Christian Schools
Gilbert Christian Schools
Greater Atlanta Christian School
Little Rock Christian Academy
Jupiter Christian School
Regent School of Austin
Southwest Christian High School
Cincinnati Hills Christian Academy
Linfield Christian School
Timothy Christian Schools
Silverdale Baptist Academy
Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy

VENTURE FIRMS

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Live Oak Ventures
Wave Ventures
Eagle Venture Fund
Fireroad
11 Tribes
Worldview
Waterstone Impact Fund
Mission 3A
Keystone Capital
Stackhouse Ventures
Our Appologies
Sandbox.Fund

ORGANIZATIONS

Praxis
Faith Driven Entrepreneur
Gloo
Solving
Venture Forge
Christian Economic Forum
National Christian Foundation
Impact Foundation
The Signatry
Talanton
CESA
ACSI
SeedTree Group
Schools United
Classical Conversations
Classic Learning Test

11 · QUESTIONS

Questions

What does it cost the school?

Nothing. Partner schools are never charged. Families pay tuition for the course, with need-based scholarships available.

How many students can we nominate?

Typically two to five per term. There is no quota. Schools whose students deliver tend to place more of them.

Does it interfere with school?

It should not. Builder Scholars spend about 3 hours a week, mostly in one team meeting and short tasks. There is no homework and there are no tests.

What credit do students earn?

College credit, awarded through Austin Christian University and transferable as each receiving college decides.

Who supervises students under 18?

Every team has an adult project lead and is overseen by studio staff. Meetings are scheduled and online. See the Supervision section of the parents' booklet for details.

What does the school get?

A place for its strongest students to do work at the level they are capable of, a record of that work, and recognition as a partner school.

12 · NEXT STEPS

Next steps

1

Name a contact

Reply to the email this booklet came in with the name of the person who will nominate students.

2

Nominate students

Send the names of two to five students. The studio contacts each student and family directly.

3

See the work

At the end of each term the school receives a summary of what its students delivered.

CONTACT

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gowest.ventures

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VENTURES

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